$$\neq 1000^2 + 2 \times 1000 \times 1000 = 3{,}000{,}000.$$

These two results differ significantly.

It is hard for most of Wheeler's colleagues to believe that this conservative, highly proper man was aware of his phrase's prurient interpretation. But I suspect otherwise; I have seen his impish streak, in private, on rare occasion.[4] Wheeler's phrase quickly took hold, despite resistance from Simon Pasternak, the editor-in-chief of the *Physical Review*, the journal in which most Western black-hole research is published. When Werner Israel tried to use the phrase in a technical paper in late 1969, Pasternak fired off a peremptory note that under no circumstances would he allow such obscenities in his journal. But Pasternak could not hold back for long the flood of "no-hair" papers. In France and the U.S.S.R., where the French- and Russian-language translations of Wheeler's phrase were also regarded as unsavory, the resistance lasted longer. By the late 1970s, however, Wheeler's phrase was being used and published by physicists worldwide, in all languages, without even a flicker of a childish grin.

It was the winter of 1964–65 by the time Ginzburg, and Dorosh-kevich, Novikov, and Zel'dovich, had invented their *no-hair conjecture* and mustered their evidence for it. Once every three years, experts on general relativity gathered somewhere in the world for a one-week scientific conference to exchange ideas and show each other the results of their researches. The fourth such conference would be held in London in June.

Nobody on Zel'dovich's team had ever traveled beyond the borders of the Communist bloc of nations. Zel'dovich himself would surely not be allowed to go; his contact with weapons research was much too recent. Novikov, however, was too young to have been involved in the hydrogen bomb project, his knowledge of general relativity was the best of anyone on the team (which is why Zel'dovich had recruited him onto the team in the first place), he was now the team's captain (Zel'-dovich was the coach), and his English was passable though far from fluent. He was the logical choice.

This was a good period in East–West relations. Stalin's death a dozen years earlier had triggered a gradual resumption of correspondence and visits between Soviet scientists and their Western colleagues (though not